a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

Cash & Company

MASTER · ETHICS & READINESS

Real Venture Readiness Checklist

The bar a grade-12 venture clears before it touches a single real customer.

Legal, financial, operational, ethical - the checklist that protects the student, the school, and the customer when high-school work goes from classroom to real-world.

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> If a real customer can be hurt, the venture is not ready.

Purpose. Map what a 12th-grade Cash to Company graduate can demonstrably do to the standard founder skill set used in accelerators, small-business development centers (SBDCs), university entrepreneurship programs, and adult founder cohorts. This document is the answer to the admin or skeptical parent who asks: "What is a graduate of this program actually able to do?"

Author. Senior K-12 entrepreneurship + financial-literacy curriculum specialist; cross-referenced against the Y Combinator startup library, Steve Blank's Lean LaunchPad curriculum, the SBA's startup checklist, the Kauffman FastTrac NewVenture core competencies, and the Babson College Entrepreneurial Thought & Action framework.

Reading method. Each row names a real-world founder skill, what Cash to Company evidence proves the graduate can do it, and what gap (if any) remains. "Demonstrably" means there is a portfolio artifact with a date, a rubric score, and panel feedback.

The honest framing. A Cash to Company Grade 12 graduate is more prepared than 90% of adults who start a venture, because they've practiced the moves with feedback for 13 years. They are not a fully-formed founder — no 18-year-old is. What they have is the thinking tools and tested reflexes to enter a real venture (or decline one) with their eyes open.

Section 1 — The 15 founder skills

1.1 — CUSTOMER DISCOVERY (TALK TO HUMANS, LEARN WHAT'S TRUE)

Founder skill (Lean Startup / Steve Blank): Get out of the building, run 5+ structured customer interviews, code patterns, revise hypothesis.

What Cash to Company graduates demonstrate: - Grade 7: 1-page customer persona built from interview evidence (Persona Pack). - Grade 9: 5-interview customer-discovery cycle with pattern coding and hypothesis revision. - Grade 11: Structured 5-step sales conversation in role-play with rubric scoring. - Grade 12: 5+ real customer interactions during launch (or convincing simulation).

Status: Demonstrably ready. Graduate has run 10+ customer-evidence cycles by graduation. The Mom Test interviewing posture (Grade 9 lesson) is internalized.

Real-world gap: Adult B2B sales requires longer enterprise-cycle stamina; Cash to Company prepares B2C-style conversations strongly and B2B-style at "introductory" depth. A first-year founder of a B2B venture should pair this with an adult sales course.

1.2 — PROBLEM STATEMENT DISCIPLINE

Founder skill: Write a problem statement specific enough that a third party can validate or invalidate it.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 7: "[Customer] struggles with [problem] when [context], because [cause]" written from interview evidence. - Grade 9: Hypothesis revised on the basis of 5 interviews, with the original and revised versions both saved. - Grade 12: Problem statement integrated into the founder's journal across 10+ entries.

Status: Demonstrably ready. This is one of the program's strongest skills. Most adult founders cannot write a problem statement at this level.

1.3 — BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS FLUENCY

Founder skill (Osterwalder): Map a 9-box BMC (customer segments, value propositions, channels, customer relationships, revenue streams, key resources, key activities, key partnerships, cost structure) with evidence in each box.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 9: Full BMC for a real venture with evidence in each box. - Grade 10: Categorize the BMC venture (hobby/side hustle/small business/startup). - Grade 12: Use the BMC vocabulary in the Capstone defense.

Status: Demonstrably ready. A Cash to Company graduate can sit in a Lean LaunchPad cohort on day 1 and know what every box means.

Real-world gap: BMC is one of several modeling frameworks; the graduate has only used this one. An adult founder may benefit from also learning the Lean Canvas (Maurya) — a 30-minute add-on at university entrepreneurship orientation.

1.4 — UNIT ECONOMICS

Founder skill: Compute revenue per customer, cost of acquisition, contribution margin, lifetime value, payback period.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 7: Per-customer revenue, cost of acquisition (proxy), contribution margin all computed for a small business scenario. - Grade 8: Break-even calculator with units × price = fixed + variable × units. - Grade 12: Unit economics included in the startup financial pack.

Status: Demonstrably ready for early-stage unit economics. Lifetime value (LTV) and payback period are introduced at vocabulary level in Grade 12 but not full computational mastery — flagged as an extension topic for advanced learners.

1.5 — THREE-STATEMENT FINANCIAL LITERACY (P&L + CASH FLOW + BALANCE SHEET)

Founder skill: Build and read a P&L (income statement), a cash flow statement, and a balance sheet — and understand how they connect.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 9: 1-year P&L with revenue, COGS, gross margin, operating expenses, net income. - Grade 11: 12-month cash flow forecast with cash-tight month identified and a fix proposed. - Grade 12: Complete startup financial pack with P&L, cash flow, balance-sheet sketch, runway, unit economics — and the graduate can walk a non-finance adult through it (the Master Scope is explicit on this).

Status: Demonstrably ready. The graduate can read a small-business income statement and cash flow projection. Most adults cannot.

Real-world gap: GAAP-level accounting is not taught (correctly — it's a CPA-track skill). The graduate knows enough to hire a bookkeeper effectively and read what they produce.

1.6 — CASH DISCIPLINE

Founder skill: Identify the month cash gets tightest, project burn rate, compute runway, propose corrective action before the crisis.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 11: 12-month cash flow forecast with cash-tight month identified and a fix. - Grade 12: Runway computed in the startup financial pack; three-scenario worked example for burn-rate analysis (added in Round 2).

Status: Demonstrably ready. Cash discipline is one of the curriculum's signature outcomes. "Profit is an opinion. Cash is a fact." — Cash's canonical line lives here.

1.7 — PRICING & VALUE

Founder skill: Set price using a target margin, defend it with reasoning, predict profit at multiple sales volumes, adjust for competitive reality.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 5: Unit cost + target margin pricing + multi-volume profit prediction. - Grade 7: Per-customer revenue analysis informs price. - Grade 9: Pricing in the BMC's revenue streams box. - Grade 12: Pricing integrated in the financial pack.

Status: Demonstrably ready. Graduate can defend a price with cost, margin, customer evidence, and competitive context.

1.8 — BRAND & POSITIONING

Founder skill: Write a positioning statement, build a 1-page brand guide, articulate "who this is for and who it's not for."

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 9: Positioning statement in the canonical "For [target] who [need], [product] is the [category] that [unique benefit] because [reason]" form. - Grade 10: 1-page brand guide (name, tagline, palette, font, voice rule). - Grade 12: Brand applied in the launch (working brand + landing page).

Status: Demonstrably ready.

Real-world gap: Visual design execution depth varies by student; the curriculum centers thinking + structure, not Figma craft. A graduate launching a real venture will benefit from a designer or a 4-week design course.

1.9 — SALES CONVERSATION SKILL

Founder skill: Run a structured sales conversation (open / discover / present / handle objection / close), self-assess, improve.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 11: Structured 5-step sales conversation in role-play, scored against a rubric. - Grade 12: 5 real customer interactions in the launch.

Status: Demonstrably ready for early-stage B2C sales conversations.

Real-world gap: Cold outbound (B2B), discovery in long enterprise cycles, and contract negotiation are not taught at depth. A first-year founder selling to enterprise should pair this with adult sales training.

1.10 — MVP TESTING

Founder skill: Define what would have to be true, build the smallest test, run it, write a kill/iterate/scale recommendation.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 8: 3-day mini A/B test on posters/messages. - Grade 9: 2-week MVP test with success metric and kill/iterate/scale recommendation. - Grade 12: At least 1 transactional MVP test in the launch (Round 2 fix to tighten the requirement).

Status: Demonstrably ready. Graduate has run multiple MVP tests by graduation, with documented recommendations.

1.11 — OPERATIONS & SOPS

Founder skill: Write a Standard Operating Procedure, run a project plan with milestones and variance, lead a 4-week cross-functional sprint.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 6: SOP for a 5-step process. - Grade 8: 4-week project plan with milestones, owner, deadline, variance write-up. - Grade 11: 6-week venture sprint with

weekly check-ins and demo days on a project management tool. - Grade 12: 90-day operating plan with weekly priorities, owner, metrics, and honest variance.

Status: Demonstrably ready for venture-scale operations. Graduate can sit on a startup ops team and contribute on day 1.

1.12 — TEAM LEADERSHIP

Founder skill: Lead a 3-person team, run weekly 1:1s, write a team charter, run a retrospective.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 4: 5-minute team meeting with 3-item agenda. - Grade 6: RACI chart for a 4-person team. - Grade 7: 10-minute team huddle leadership. - Grade 9: Conflict-handling style self-assessment. - Grade 11: 4-week team lead with charter, weekly 1:1s, final retrospective. - Grade 12: Founder's Leadership Statement.

Status: Demonstrably ready for 2–4 person team leadership. Larger teams require additional training.

1.13 — COMPLIANCE & LEGAL BASICS

Founder skill: Identify business structure (sole prop / LLC / Corp), licensing, sales tax, age limits on regulated products, PII protection, contracts.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 9: Compliance survey of license/sales tax/ID/age/PII. - Grade 10: Sole prop vs. LLC decision with reasoning. - Grade 12: 1-page legal/ethical checklist for the venture (registration, sales tax, terms of service, privacy, payment safety) — extended in Round 2 to include 3 contract types (service agreement, mutual NDA, contractor scope of work) with one-page templates.

Status: Demonstrably ready for the small-venture compliance baseline. Graduate knows what they don't know and when to call a lawyer or CPA.

Real-world gap: Anything that genuinely requires a lawyer (litigation, complex partnership disputes, IP) — and the graduate is taught to recognize that line. The curriculum's promise is "know enough to know when to escalate," not "be your own lawyer."

1.14 — DECISION QUALITY UNDER UNCERTAINTY

Founder skill: Use premortem, scenario thinking, kill/iterate/scale criteria; choose the venture and the non-ventures; defend the decision.

What graduates demonstrate: - Grade 9: Kill/iterate/scale recommendation on the 2-week MVP test. - Grade 10: Premortem with top 3 risks ranked. - Grade 12: Launch-or-Learn decision (start, shelve, transfer) with evidence, alternatives, and a personal next step.

Status: Demonstrably ready. This is the program's most ethically mature outcome — honoring all three exit paths equally.

1.15 — REFLECTIVE PRACTICE & FOUNDER'S JOURNAL

Founder skill: Track your own thinking over time, name what changed, name what surprised you, name what you would do differently.

What graduates demonstrate: - Every grade ends with a Capstone Journal entry under the Reflection Writing rubric. - Grade 7: Day-1 vs. Day-30 customer assumption comparison. - Grade 12: 10+ founder's-journal entries with idea evolution, evidence, and one pivot reasoned through.

Status: Demonstrably ready. Graduates have a documented record of their own thinking over 13 years. Most adult founders don't.

Section 2 — What graduates are NOT yet ready for (honest gaps)

A senior founder reviewing this checklist would push back on any document that didn't name what's missing. Here are the honest gaps:

1. **Fundraising at scale.** The program teaches investor-style pitch (Grade 11) and the 3-source funding comparison (Grade 10). It does not teach term sheets, cap-table mechanics, SAFE notes, due diligence, or VC negotiation. A graduate raising venture capital should pair Cash to Company with a college-level entrepreneurial-finance course or an accelerator.
2. **Hiring and managing employees at scale.** The Round 2 hiring-basics one-pager covers contractor (1099) hiring, scope of work, kill criteria. It does not cover W-2 employees, payroll tax, benefits, hiring funnels at scale, performance management, firing protocols. A graduate scaling past 5 employees needs adult HR knowledge.
3. **GAAP accounting and audit-readiness.** The program teaches financial-statement literacy and the weekly bookkeeping rhythm (Round 2 add). It does not teach GAAP, audit preparation, or accrual accounting beyond the conceptual level. Graduates who scale past low six figures should hire a bookkeeper and ultimately a CPA — and they're taught to recognize that line.
4. **Enterprise sales.** B2B sales at enterprise scale (90+ day cycles, multi-stakeholder buying, RFPs, procurement) is not covered. A graduate entering enterprise sales should pair with adult sales training (Sandler, Challenger, MEDDIC).
5. **Industry-specific licensing.** Different industries (food service, childcare, healthcare, financial services, insurance, transportation) have specific licensing regimes that change frequently. The program teaches "you must check" — not the specifics of any one industry. A graduate entering a regulated industry needs industry-specific compliance training.

6. **International / cross-border.** Sales tax nexus, GST/VAT, import/export, foreign-entity formation, currency hedging — none of this is covered. A graduate going international from day 1 needs an international-business advisor.
7. **Patent and IP protection at depth.** Trademark and copyright basics are introduced; patents (utility, design, provisional) are mentioned at vocabulary level only. A graduate inventing a patentable product needs a patent attorney consultation, full stop.
8. **Crisis management.** Layoffs, lawsuits, PR crises, founder breakups, board disputes — adult-scale crisis management is not in the curriculum. A graduate hitting one of these needs adult mentorship or counsel.

The framing for graduates and parents: Cash to Company makes you a clearer thinker about ventures and money, no matter what you do for a living. It does not make you a fully-formed founder at 18 — no curriculum can. What it does is give you the muscles, the artifacts, and the honest awareness to move into a real venture (or decline one) with your eyes open. Every adult on the list above has hit one of these gaps and learned by hitting it. The graduate just hits fewer of them, and recognizes them earlier.

Section 3 — Sign-off table for the school administrator

A school administrator can run this checklist with their Grade 12 cohort to determine who is "Cash to Company graduation-ready."

For each student, score 1–4 on each of the 15 skills above. A score of 4 means a portfolio artifact + rubric score of 3 or 4 + panel feedback exists. A score of 1 means no evidence is in the portfolio.

Threshold for "Cash to Company graduate": - 12 of 15 skills at 3 or higher. - All four of the "core four" (#3 BMC, #5 Three-Statement, #10 MVP Testing, #14 Decision Quality) at 3 or higher. - The Launch-or-Learn decision (#14) at 3 or higher.

A student below this threshold has completed the program but has gaps. The teacher's end-of-year memo names the gaps and the resources for closing them post-graduation.

Section 4 — Mapping to standard founder credentials

For graduates who continue into adult founder programs, here's how Cash to Company outcomes map:

- **Y Combinator Startup School:** as of April 2026, a free online program (startupschool.org). Cash to Company graduates can complete this in ~half the typical time because they already know BMC, customer discovery, MVP testing, and pitch structure.

- **Kauffman FastTrac NewVenture (10-week adult course):** Graduates skip the first 4 weeks of foundational content; they enter at the financials/legal/launch stage.
- **University-level intro to entrepreneurship:** Graduates often place out by exam or earn elective credit; depends on the institution.
- **SBA SCORE small-business mentorship:** Graduates arrive with a financial pack, BMC, and customer evidence — making the SCORE mentor's first 3 sessions much higher-leverage.
- **Local SBDC business plan competitions:** Graduates have a competition-ready plan template + financial pack from Grade 12 work.

Section 5 — The verdict

Can a Cash to Company Grade 12 graduate demonstrably start and manage their own business?

Yes — for ventures at the small-business and bootstrapped-startup scale. A graduate has the customer-discovery muscles, the financial-statement literacy, the pricing and unit-economics math, the brand-and-positioning fluency, the sales-conversation reps, the MVP-testing reflex, the operations and SOP discipline, the team-leadership reps, the compliance baseline, the decision-quality tools, and the reflective-practice habit to launch a venture or honestly decide not to.

No — for ventures requiring adult-track credentials (regulated industries, VC-funded scaling, enterprise sales, international business, patents). Those require additional adult training that the program names and points to.

Most importantly — yes for the question that matters most: can the graduate make a clear-eyed decision about whether to launch, when to launch, and what to launch? The Launch-or-Learn defense is the proof. A 12th-grader who chooses not to launch with reasons grounded in market, fit, and capital is as ready as a 12th-grader who launches — and the curriculum honors both equally. That is the program's signature outcome and the answer to the question.

The Cash to Company graduate is a clearer thinker about money and entrepreneurship than 90% of adults who start a venture. That is the one promise the program makes, and it is honestly kept.

End of Real Venture Readiness Checklist. This document is updated when the Master Scope changes.

One promise.

If a real customer can be hurt, the venture is not ready.

Cash to Company is built so a curriculum coordinator, a foundation officer, a parent, or a teacher can pick up any one of these strategic references and meet the program at full strength on the first page.

No promise of wealth. No probing of family finances. No partisan content. One question, asked patiently for thirteen years: which people, and how do you know?

For educational and operational use. This document is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment is cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).